Getting supplies to their troops was not as big a problem for the Chinese as it was for the Indians because of the roads that had been built years before the attack. Several of those led right down to the LAC, opposite the NEFA in the east. In the west, there was the highway that the Chinese had built through Aksai Chin connecting Xinjiang with Tibet.

After the Indian defences near Thagla and Bumla had been obliterated, the PLA was able to march down to Tawang. At 3,048 metres above sea level, Tawang is still high up in the mountains, but in a relatively fertile valley well below the much higher peaks and passes along the frontier. As soon as Tawang was captured and the surrounding area secured by the PLA, thousands of porters, construction workers—and bulldozers and heavy machinery—poured across Bumla. Working round the clock in three shifts, it took the Chinese only 13 days to construct a road from the pass to Tawang, a distance of nearly 40 kilometres through extremely difficult and mountainous terrain. The PLA trucks now rolled into Tawang, which now became a major supply base for the Chinese. Then they pushed south, and the strategic Sela Pass, 78 kilometres south of Tawang, was in Chinese hands after a fierce battle with Indian troops. On 19 November, the Chinese juggernaut reached the town of Bomdila, 170 kilometres south of Tawang. The Chinese were now only a few days' march from Assam and the fertile plains around the River Brahmaputra.

By that time, the war had spread as Chinese troops had crossed into the far eastern corner of the NEFA. On 22 October, the Chinese launched an attack on an Indian outpost at Kibihtoo, north of the small town of Walong near the border with Myanmar. After a lull in the fighting, the PLA resumed its advance on 13 November, and Walong was overrun three days later. The PLA units also attacked and captured some villages in what the Indians then called the Subansiri and Siang Frontier Divisions immediately south of the Line of Control (LoC) in the central sector of the NEFA.

There was total panic on the Indian side. Outgunned and overwhelmed by a superior force, India's defences in the NEFA had crumbled and Indian soldiers were in retreat from the entire territory. Many believed that the PLA would march on to capture Assam with its oil fields, tea gardens, jute plantations, and other riches. Even the garrison town of Tezpur in the Brahmaputra Valley was evacuated as the Indians awaited what seemed to be the inevitable outcome of the debacle in the Himalayas.